INDIA'S LONGEST-SERVING CMs

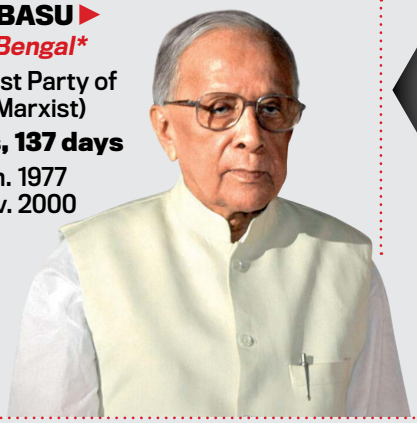
Six leaders who have spent more than two decades in office



▲ PAWAN KUMAR CHAMLING
*Sikkim**
Sikkim Democratic Front
24 years, 165 days
● Dec. 1994 to May 2019



JYOTI BASU ▶
*West Bengal**
Communist Party of India (Marxist)
23 years, 137 days
● Jun. 1977 to Nov. 2000





◀ GEGONG APANG
Arunachal Pradesh
Congress, Arunachal Congress, United Democratic Front, BJP, Congress
22 years, 250 days
● Jan. 1980 to Jan. 1999
● Aug. 2003 to Apr. 2007

▶ NAVEEN PATNAIK
*Odisha**
Biju Janata Dal
24 years, 85 days#
● Mar. 2000 (incumbent)

**Consecutive terms; #till May 29*

LAL THANHAWLA ▼
Mizoram, Congress
22 years, 60 days
● May 1984 to Aug. 1986
● Jan. 1989 to Dec. 1998
● Dec. 2008 to Dec. 2018



VIRBHADRA SINGH ▶
Himachal Pradesh
Congress
21 years, 13 days
● Apr. 1983 to Mar. 1990
● Dec. 1993 to Mar. 1998
● Mar. 2003 to Dec. 2007
● Dec. 2012 to Dec. 2017



Assistance for Livelihood and Income Augmentation), a package to help farmers and reduce poverty. But the loudest roar of affirmation came when he asked humbly, "Is Naveen Patnaik good?" The chief minister then asked the people to press the Jodi Sankha (twin conches) on the ballot machine for both the assembly and the Lok Sabha candidates.

Not only is Naveen avoiding criticism of his opponents, he is also refusing to play the caste and religion cards to seek votes. He goes by the belief that "When your works speaks for itself, let it." His certainly does. When Naveen first took over as chief minister on March 5, 2000, all odds were against him succeeding. A Doon School alumnus who had Sanjay Gandhi, the younger son of Indira Gandhi, as his classmate, Naveen was born and raised in privilege. His father was the legendary Biju Patnaik, the CM of Odisha, but Naveen was least interested in politics, absorbed instead in a jet-setting lifestyle, which included frequent travels abroad and rubbing shoulders with the likes of Jacqueline Kennedy Onassis and Mick Jagger. He wrote books on exotic plants and Indian history, ran a boutique in Delhi and embraced permanent bachelorhood. But forced to take over his father's legacy after his death in 1997, Naveen founded the BJD and served for a brief while in the Vajpayee government as the Union minister for steel and mines. After his party, in alliance with the BJP, won a majority in the 2000 assembly election and defeated the Congress, Naveen took over as CM and turned his back forever on the good life in Delhi.

Back then, Odisha was considered one of India's poorest and most backward states, infamous for its famines, cyclones and corruption. Naveen went about setting things right with a vengeance. Shunning opulence, he adopted a frugal lifestyle, dressing in a white cotton kurta-pyjama and staying in the outhouse of his father's sprawling bungalow in Bhubaneswar. Though he couldn't speak the language fluently (his critics say he still can't), Naveen got